

Exploring Nazi Fascism

SS 30-2

Unit 2-Chapter 7



What is Fascism?

Unlike communism which allows for social freedoms, but opposes economic freedoms, **fascism supports some economic freedoms and strongly opposes social freedoms.**

Fascism is often associated with ultranationalism and racism, as it usually idealizes a monocultural past.



Fascism Rejects Liberal Ideas Such As...

The idea that each individual has a right to life, liberty, and property. Fascism argues only some have that right, others are unworthy.

Fascism is quite incompatible with the idea of democracy and in practice democratically elected fascist leaders have gone on to become dictators.



How are Fascism and Communism Different?

- Communism is embracing equality to extremes. **Communism strives for complete social and economic equality.** Communism draws inspiration from an idealized future utopia.
- Fascism is an extreme resistance to equality. **Fascism strives for social and economic inequality.** Fascism usually draws inspiration from an idealized past.





Political Ideas

- Cult of the leader and elite rule
- Extreme nationalism
- Organized violence and war and military force
- It is in the country's interest to expand territory

Economic Ideas

- A government directed-directed private enterprise economy to serve the needs and interests of the state
- anti-union/ anti-workers' rights

Social Ideas

- Inequalities between individuals and groups of individuals
- Racial purity
- Racial or national superiority
- National strength more important than individual rights

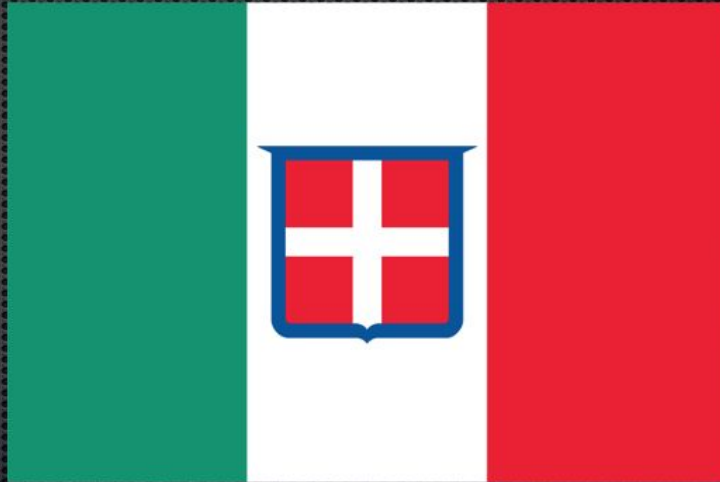
Understanding Fascism

- Look at the economic spectrum on page 173
- What are the key aspects of Fascism according to the economic spectrum?

How Did Fascism Start?

Fascism began in Italy after the First World War. Italian Fascist leader **Benito Mussolini** was **very charismatic and called for Italy to be more nationalistic, and more powerful on the world stage.**

Fascism is often associated with militarism.



Why Was Fascism Popular?

- Fascism was very attractive to people who believed in ideas such as: **Eugenics (Survival of the Fittest or Social Darwinism)**, **traditional nationalistic values**, and **intense anti-communism**.
- In Europe leading up to the Second World War, Fascists became the leaders of Italy and Germany. Fascist parties were also very popular in Britain, France, and Spain.
- Many thought that the first world war was brought about by liberalism, as these governments are weak and unstable.
- Hitler's Germany tried to recreate the ideal Germany of before the First World War. **A Germany populated by Aryans and untouched by foreign influences.**

Pg. 173 Second Paragraph

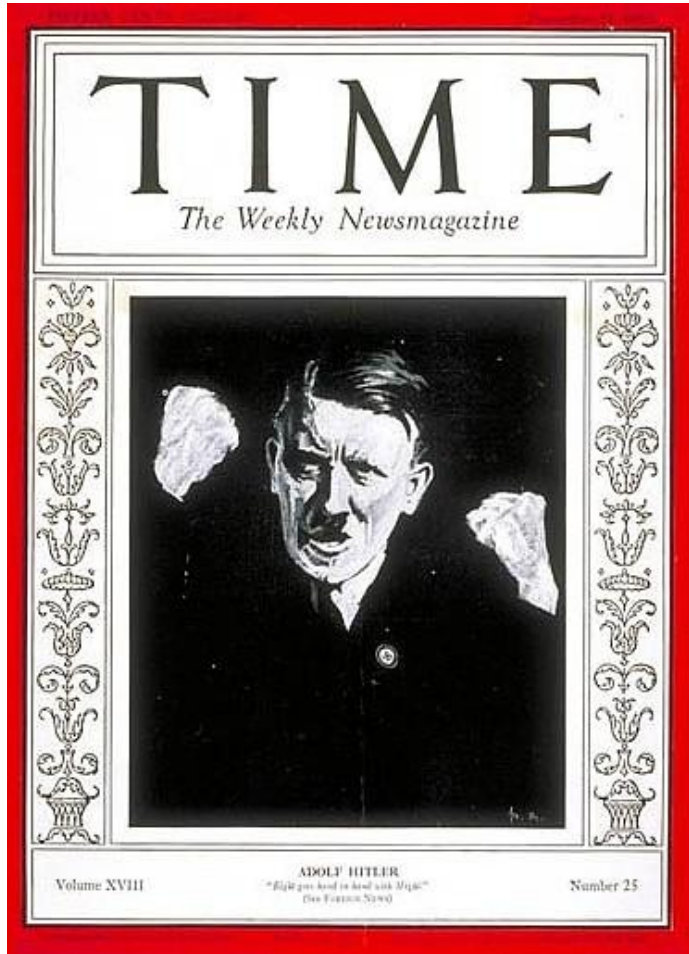


The Treaty of Versailles

- This treaty really led to a series of problems that at least indirectly was part of the cause of WWII.
- The terms of the treaty:
 - Germany must give up some of its won territory and all of its overseas colonies
 - Accept responsibility for causing all loss and damage to Allied governments
 - Pay the equivalent of US\$4.5 billion in reparations to allied governments between 1919 and 1921; with additional interest after.
 - in 1923, Germany simply stopped paying
 - from 1918-1923 the German mark's value decreased.
 - 1 US was equal to 8.25 German marks vs 1 US= 4 200 000 000 000 German Marks



- The German government had irresponsibly been printing money, therefore decreasing the value.
- As a result German people faced *hyperinflation*.
- furthermore a drop in living standards and unemployment were problematic in the 1920's



- The German liberal - democratic government was facing the most serious economic problems ever seen by a liberal democratic state
 - High unemployment
 - Low currency value
 - High inflation
 - Massive drop in standard of living



- In the 1920's the Americans were lending money to the Germans in an attempt to help their economy
- However by the 1930's when the Great Depression hit those loans stopped and Germany went farther into economic turmoil



- Many people in Germany blamed the Liberal democratic government for not effectively dealing with the economic issues facing Germany



- There was also political unrest in Germany through the 1920's and 30's
- Many new political parties began to form including the Nazi Party and the National Socialist German Workers Party



- Economic and Political unrest was a major factor in the rise of Hitler in Germany
- However, there was also a distrust and even hatred for Communism by the German business owners
- The world watched Russian go through a revolution and turn to communism in 1917 and Germany did not want the same to happen there.

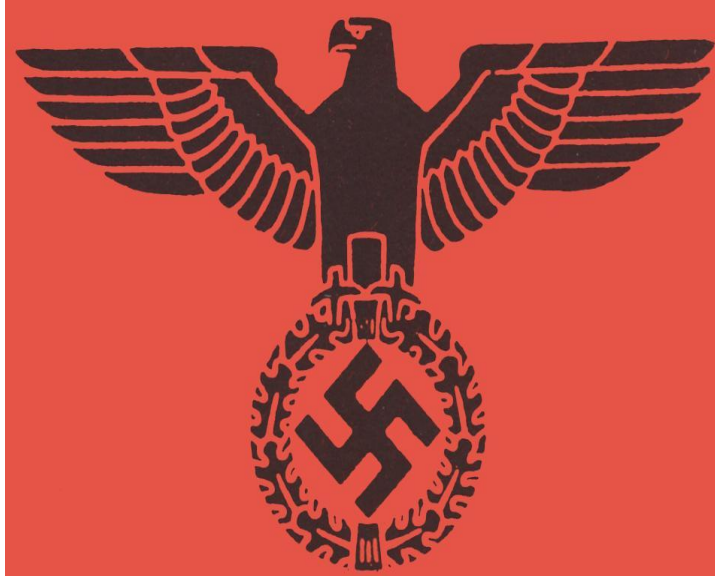
Germans questioned

- communism, as they had seen Communist Russia through the Revolution of 1917
- liberalism, as the Depression stole their life savings
- Living and working conditions were deteriorating,
- Germany needed a strong leader, and multi party democracy was not working in Germany

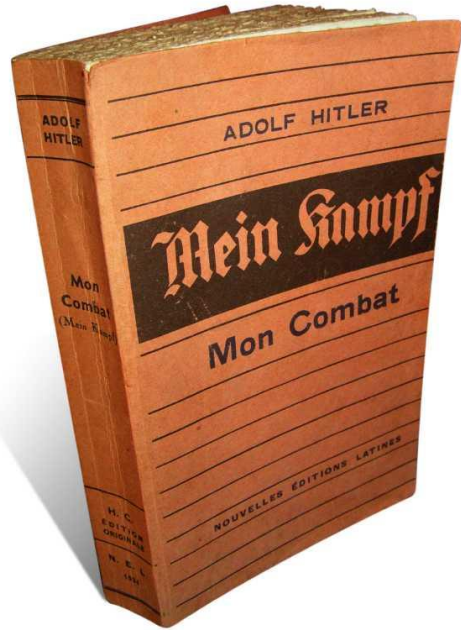
Rise of the Nazis

- The ideology of fascism in Nazi Germany was in part an expression of Adolf Hitler's deep-seated hatred of liberalism, Jews, and communists.
- Rise of the Nazis
 - <http://www.youtube.com/watch?v=a2YEUhHFMHY>





- In the 1920's Hitler started to become more popular within his party
- He decided that the Nazi party would need to take over control of the government by force
- In 1923 he tried and failed, he was sent to jail and the Nazi party was banned.



- While in prison Hitler wrote a book called Mein Kampf (My Struggle)
- This book would be the influence behind fascism Germany for the years to follow.



- In 1925 Hitler promised to use only legal means to promote his politics. He was released from prison and the ban on the Nazi party was lifted
- Support for the party began to grow
- Violence also began to grow with regular street fights between the Nazi party and the Communist Party

Consolidating Power

- November 1932-German elections-Nazi party receives 33% of the popular vote and about 1/3 of the seats in the Reichstag.
- January 1933-Hitler becomes chancellor.
- He quickly transforms Germany into a totalitarian state



- In 1933 Hitler became the Chancellor of Germany, leader of the democratically elected government
- Shortly after a fire was started in the Reichstag and was blamed on the Communists as a sign of the impending revolution.



- A snap election was called and the Nazis became the party of power and formed the government
- Soon after Hitler passed the Enabling Act, this eliminated all political oppositions and many individual rights and freedoms. Germany rejected Liberalism and adopted Dictatorship in the form of Nazism

Hitler the Dictator



- Hitler formed his own brand of Fascism called Nazism
- His Ideology was different in that it included the idea of one superior race, the Aryans



Nazism and the German Economy

- While individual rights were taken away the economy benefited from the Nazis.
- Between 1932 and 1936 unemployment fell from 6 million to less than 1 million.
- Companies that supported the Nazis financially benefitted from the ban on trade unions and strikes.
- Many massive public projects such as the construction of the autobahn provided much employment.



Nazism and the German Economy continued ...

- Germany started to re-arm its military and farming and industries were given government subsidies.
- Foreign imports were restricted in order to encourage consumption of German-made goods.
- All of this was created in order to achieve self sufficiency or independence from other nations.
- The negative of this was that workers had few rights and companies were severely regulated and access to raw materials and output was controlled.



- Hitler used many techniques to gain support
 - Propaganda
 - Youth Movements
 - Elimination of his opposition
 - The use of terror and force (Gestapo (secret police) and the SS and SA)
 - Scapegoats



- These tactics were able to reduce the ideas of liberalism gaining strength in Germany
- He also took individual rights and freedoms away from groups that did not fit into his ideal society including Jews, Roma people, people with mental and physical disabilities, homosexuals, feminists, communists, people with different views than his own



Hitler's Purge:

- Night of the Long Knives - Hitler, like Stalin, purged his own paramilitary group (the SA) and executed a Nazi top official leader Ernst Rohm in order to protect his grip on power.



- One of the key ideas of fascism was the idea of dominating other cultural and racial groups.
- This was necessary because ethnic differences would make it difficult to build a disciplined, obedient and powerful state

Social Darwinism



- In 1859 Charles Darwin wrote a book entitled *On the Origin of Species*
- In this book he proposed a popular idea that animals evolve through natural selection
- The strongest and fittest survive and the weak do not, thus creating a stronger species

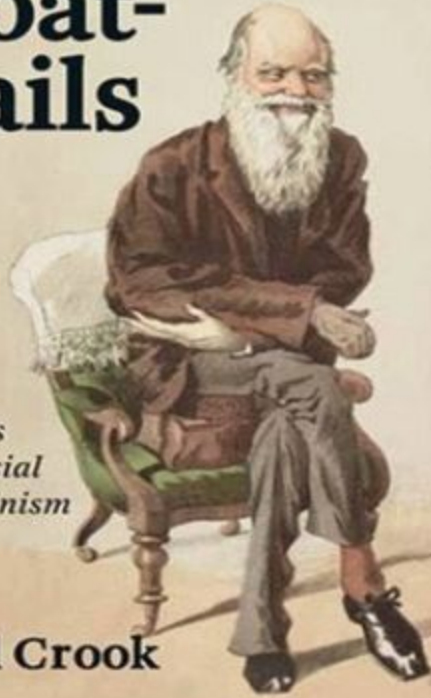


- Some governments related the ideas of Darwin to societies, cultures and races. This became the ideology of Social Darwinism
- Social Darwinism promoted the idea that certain races, groups, societies should dominate others because they are stronger

Darwin's Coat-Tails

*Essays
on Social
Darwinism*

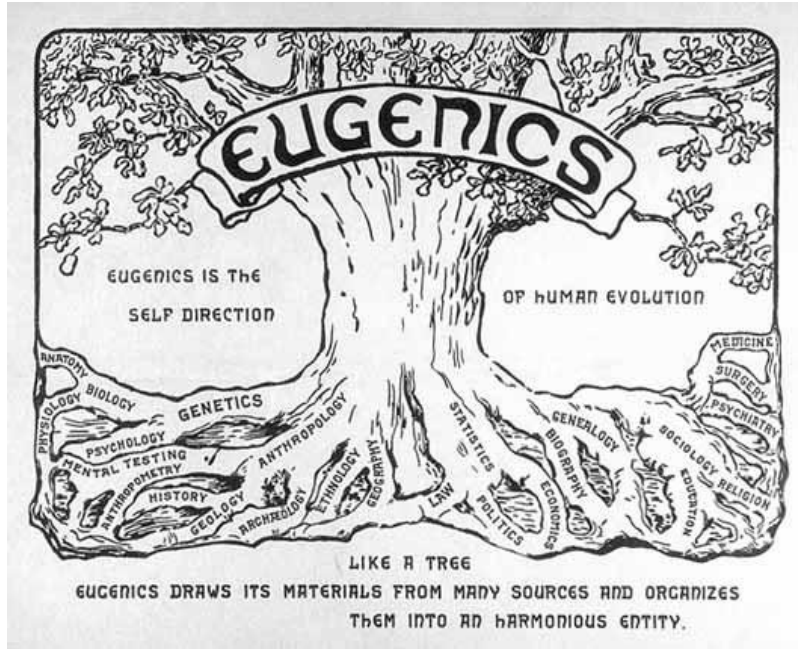
Paul Crook



- All ideologies have used the ideas of social Darwinism from time to time to promote their ideas
- Liberals used these ideas to promote laissez-faire economics and political conservatism



- Other suggested that it was natural to have different classes as people had variations in abilities
- These social classes were said to be necessary in order to improve society



- Related to the ideas of Social Darwinism are the ideas of Eugenics
- Eugenics is the idea that society could be improved by selective breeding or genocide
- Individuals with admirable traits such as academics or athletics would be encouraged to breed, others with disabilities or of less desirable racial backgrounds would be killed off



- Some fascists adopted the ideas of Social Darwinism and Eugenics to justify policies of violence against individuals
- The idea of survival of the fittest was also embraced in order to make a country that was strong enough to survive against other states

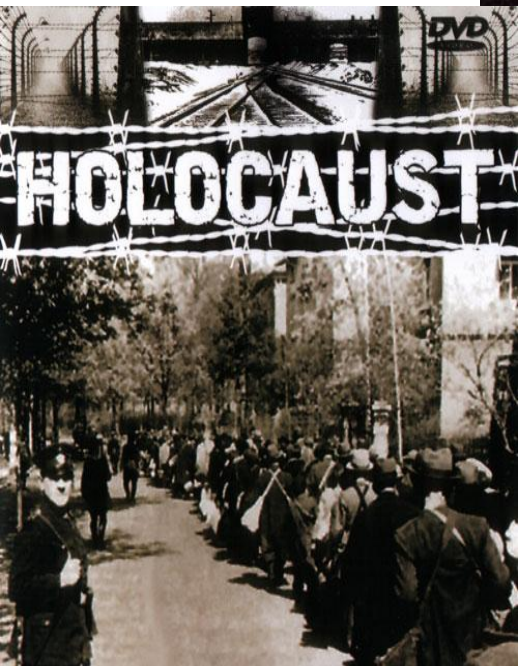
Prosecution of the Jews and Others

- The Jews and other groups were used as **scapegoats** for many of Germany's problems before Hitler came to power.
- Once in power, the Nazis began working towards the systematic elimination of Jews and members of some minority groups from Germany and eventually all of Europe.
- Starting in 1933 the German government passed a series of laws aimed at excluding people of Jewish ancestry from German society.

Prosecution of the Jews and Others continued ...

- 1933-Jews barred from working in government-being lawyers-working as editors-the number of Jewish students in public schools was strictly limited.
- 1935-Jewish officers expelled from the army.
- 1936-Jews banned from working as tax consultants-veterinarians, or teachers in public schools.

Prosecution of the Jews and Others continued ...



- 1938-Jews must report all property in excess of 5000 Reich marks/some Jewish property is confiscated and transferred to non-Jewish Germans/all Jewish businesses are closed/all Jewish students are expelled from public schools.
- Eventually all German Jews and Jewish people could be detained in concentration camps and ghettos, and often used as slave labour, before being transported to extermination camps and murdered/an estimated 6 million Jews died during the Holocaust.

Nazi Eugenics

- Under Hitler, Germany became a police state run by the Gestapo (secret police) and the SS (elite paramilitary force) who ensured that Germans followed the decrees of the Nazi party.
- An important tenet of the Nazi party was the promotion of the superiority of the pure Aryan race.

Nazi Eugenics continued ...

- In order to accomplish this eugenics-controlling human reproduction so that desirable genetic traits could be encouraged and other traits eliminated-was introduced.
- Reproduction among desirable people of Aryan background was encouraged through programs such as Lebensborn.

Lives of Aryan Germans

- The lives of Aryan Germans improved under the Nazis.
- They were provided with leisure, holidays, access to improved transportation and frequent public gatherings to promote this life.
- Patriarchy dominated the Nazi ideology.

Lives of Aryan Germans continued ...

- Women were primarily to be in the home bearing and raising children.
- Families were loaned money when they married and were given about \$1500 for each child that they had.
- Women got a gold medal for having more than eight children.
- Professional working women lost their employment and they were forbidden from serving in the armed forces.

Recruiting Youth



- Young people were courted by the government to ensure the future of the thousand-year Reich.



Fascism's Showdown with Liberalism and Communism

Nazi Germany tried to form itself into an ideal fascist state by ridding itself of minorities and political dissidents, as well as celebrating and strengthening its military accomplishments.

The Second World War was a major ideological clash in Europe with **Communists and Liberals eventually uniting to defeat Fascism.**

Consequences of Fascism

With the exception of Spain, Europe's Fascist leaders led their countries into the Second World War against far more numerous and powerful enemies, largely due to notions of superiority.

Ideas of ethnic cleansing to create the ideal past were practiced by the Nazis. 13 million people (including 6 million Jews) were killed outside of the War itself.



Fascism After the Second World War

Due to the atrocities committed by the Nazis and other fascists during the War, fascism experienced an unsurprising decline in popularity after the War.

Fascism is particularly incompatible with ideas such as Multiculturalism, as fascism promotes monoculturalism.

Fascism does not promote ideas of individuals, unless they were serving the state



Fascism Today

Recently as most of the people who lived through the realities of the War and fascism have died, fascism is going through a resurgence in popularity. Seldom do groups explicitly call themselves fascists, but far right groups have recently gained popularity in many countries such as: Japan, Germany, Greece, Britain, France, and Mongolia.

However these groups are still quite unpopular.

